is a ‘shy’ person himself, recalls that whenever he and Ratan met, it was almost a meeting in silence. There was very little conversation, but what there was, was indeed weighty. During such meetings, though they were few and far between, Ratan would give TCS an unobtrusive push. It was nothing new. While working as the director-in-charge of NELCO in the early 1970s, he had spotted the need to bring computers to India and begin developing software. He had goaded TCS not to miss being part of the huge business opportunity this offered.

Ramadorai, who was put in charge of computer maintenance and support in 1974, says, ‘Ratan Tata was far ahead of his times’, like F.C. Kohli in this aspect. Kohli himself spoke of Ratan thus: ‘He is a great man, has a great vision and is a dedicated worker.’ Recalling Ratan’s uncanny ability to spot opportunity and its potential in the long run, Ramadorai says that while at NELCO, Ratan had learned that the QANTEL computers of California were running business operations. ‘Ram, go and bring it to India’ and start making software, Ramadorai remembers Ratan telling him. Ramadorai went to California and bought a computer and, with help from IIT Bombay, built a software for it. It gave the fledgling TCS a new sense of purpose and direction.

After becoming the group chairman, Ratan reinforced the idea of TCS being a global company. Increasing the global footprint was a centrepiece of his restructuring plan. ‘He was a proponent of globalization’ and it ‘worked in our favour’, recalls Chandrasekaran.

With Ratan’s strong encouragement, TCS, which was already a global company, was encouraged to go ahead ‘further and further’, he adds. And in this pursuit, the former chairman’s vast international connections benefited the company in many ways. ‘The relationships that he had established were very important,’ says Ramadorai. ‘The international recognition and visibility he got for the group through a set of people is an amazing contribution for India and the group itself.’ According to Ramadorai, Ratan helped connect TCS with the world. He was happy to meet any customer of TCS, even at short notice, he adds.

Another aspect of the restructuring programme that was clearly aligned with TCS and helped it was Ratan’s unequivocal push for customer focus. This was also a criterion in the JRD QV/TBEM assessment matrix. The customer and market focus were together assigned 85 points. As Chandrasekaran says, TCS had a strong customer focus. ‘Many can do what